



AUSTRALIA

UNTIL ABOUT 200 YEARS AGO, the land that is now Australia was occupied only by Aborigines. Then, in 1770, the British explorer James Cook arrived in Botany Bay and claimed it for Britain. In 1901, Australia became an independent commonwealth. Over the years, settlers from overseas, first from Britain and Europe, but more recently from Asia, have shaped the culture of this huge country. Wool and wheat, as well as mineral resources of iron ore, coal, and copper, have made Australia wealthy, and most people benefit from a high standard of living.



SETTLERS

In the 18th century, British prisons were overcrowded and criminals were often sent overseas. In 1778 the first ship to Australia arrived from Britain with 757 convicts, forming a settlement in what is now Sydney. By 1860 more than 160,000 convicts had been transported.

AUSTRALIA	
Capital city:	Canberra
Area:	2,967,893 sq miles (7,686,850 sq km)
Population:	19,700,000
Official language:	English
Major religion:	Christian 64%, other 36%
Government:	Multiparty democracy
Currency:	Australian dollar
Adult literacy rate:	99%
Life expectancy:	79 years
People per doctor:	400
Televisions:	639 per 1,000 people



LIVING ON THE COAST

About 85 percent of Australians live in or around cities along the coast. Most of the schools, hospitals, offices, and factories are located there, and life is easier than in the remote towns and farms of the outback. Homes in the city are built of wood or brick, often with verandas or "sleepouts," as well as a backyard for a barbecue. The five largest cities contain

60 percent of the population. One of these is Sydney, shown left, with its Opera House overlooking the harbor.

MAIN CITIES BY POPULATION	
Sydney	4,200,000
Melbourne	3,488,750
Brisbane	1,770,000
Perth	1,433,200
Adelaide	1,072,600



Aboriginals act out their beliefs in their songs, ceremonies, and art. This group is from Queensland.

ABORIGINAL BELIEFS

The word Aboriginal means "from the beginning," and Aboriginals believe they have occupied Australia since the beginning of time. They have a detailed knowledge of the land; women gathered fruits, nuts, and grubs, and men hunted animals such as kangaroos and opossums. The Dreamtime, long ago when the land and all living things were made, is the basis of Aboriginal culture.



VAST DISTANCES

Away from the coasts, much of Australia is dry and hot, with very few towns or settlements. Alice Springs, in the center of the country, began as a station linking the telegraph line between Darwin and Adelaide. Separated by such large distances, many children cannot get to schools. They study through the special School of the Air learning program.

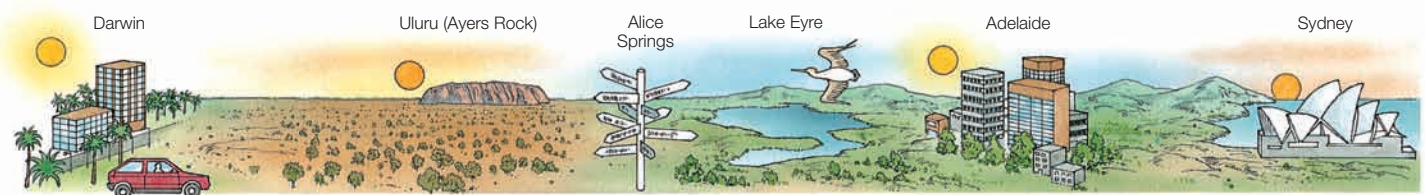
The journey from Darwin to Sydney, via Adelaide, is 2,996 miles (4,822 km). This would take about 2.5 days and nights of nonstop driving.



People in Sydney demonstrate for land rights. On the Aboriginal flag, black represents the people, yellow the Sun, and red the land.

LAND RIGHTS

The arrival of the British changed life for the Aboriginals. Many lost their land and thousands died of European diseases. Today, they no longer live off the land in the traditional way, but work in factories or farms. Many suffer from poor health and bad housing. In 1967, they were granted the right to vote. Since then a series of laws have given Aboriginals control over some of the land.



Darwin to Alice Springs
937 miles (1,508 km)

Alice Springs to Adelaide
950 miles (1,529 km)

Adelaide to Sydney
1,109 miles (1,785 km)